

What is a workflow and what is a workflow management system?

A workflow is an automated process where tasks pass between people according to set rules. A WfMS stores, runs and manages these processes (Hollingsworth, 1995; WfMC, 1996). So TIVIDY's engine must run processes without containing them.

What is the difference between a workflow definition and a running workflow instance?

A definition is the template of steps, order and roles; an instance is one run of it, with its own data and history (WfMC, 1996). So these need separate classes, and changing one instance must not affect the others.

How are activities or work items represented?

Activities create work items that go to a worklist and move through states such as waiting, active and completed (WfMC, 1996). So work items need a state-based lifecycle.

How are work items assigned and routed?

Routing uses sequence, parallel, choice and loops, and each product supports a different subset (van der Aalst et al., 2003). Work is either pushed to someone by role or workload, or pulled from a shared list (Russell et al., 2005). So both routing and assignment must be swappable, not hard-coded.

How are approvals, rejection and escalation handled?

An approval is a work item whose result decides the next step. Rejection sends work back, and escalation reassigns it when a deadline passes (WfMC, 1996; Russell et al., 2005). So deadlines and escalation rules must be configurable.

How are participants, roles and responsibilities represented?

Definitions name roles, not people, and the engine picks a person at run time from the organisation's structure (WfMC, 1996). So staff changes should not require changing definitions.

How are dependencies, events and failures handled?

Steps wait on conditions or joins, events trigger actions, and each type of failure gets a chosen response such as retry, skip or undo (WfMC, 1996; Russell, van der Aalst and ter Hofstede, 2006). So many parts must be able to react to one event, and failure handling must be configurable.

How do workflow systems interact with external systems?

Engines reach outside systems through a separate interface (Hollingsworth, 1995); Camunda, for example, queues jobs for external workers to pick up (Camunda, n.d.b). So TIVIDY needs a translation layer for each external system.

How is workflow history or audit information recorded?

Every state change is logged with a timestamp (WfMC, 1996). So actions should be stored as history objects, which also makes undo possible.

How are running workflows monitored and reported on?

Monitoring is separate from execution, and logs are analysed afterwards to find bottlenecks (Hollingsworth, 1995; van der Aalst, 2016). So reporting should read the history from outside the core classes.

What makes a workflow engine reusable across different processes?

All process rules live in the definition, not the engine (WfMC, 1996). So no scenario-specific code belongs in the engine.

Which information belongs to a workflow definition and which belongs to a running instance?

Definition: steps, order, conditions, roles and deadlines. Instance: current state, data, assigned people and history (WfMC, 1996).

How do real workflow systems model nested activities or sub-processes?

A sub-process has its own definition and can be nested inside others (WfMC, 1996). So nested work forms a tree the engine can traverse.

Which decisions are normally configurable rather than hard-coded into the workflow engine?

Routing, assignment, escalation and failure handling (WfMC, 1996; Russell et al., 2005; Russell, van der Aalst and ter Hofstede, 2006).

How are changes to workflow definitions handled while work is already in progress?

A change creates a new version, and running instances stay on the old one unless they can be safely migrated (Camunda, n.d.a; Rinderle, Reichert and Dadam, 2004). So definitions must be versioned.

Summary for our design

Repeats across products: definitions vs instances, work-item lifecycles, role-based assignment and audit history.

Changes independently: routing, assignment, escalation, failure handling, integrations and reporting.

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